

The Sun

You hate the sun. You always have; for as long as you've been you. Your first memories are of glaring at the spiteful orb above, wishing back to it all the pain that it was pouring into your eyes. You stared with all the perseverance your stubborn young eyes could muster, and all it left you with were spots in your vision; the sun having forever stolen parts of your sight.

You remember how, in your youth, you would climb the tallest hills you could find and, screaming, whip stones as cruelly as you could into the great burning eye above. You got good at throwing; good enough to lose your stones in the cutting brilliance of light, but never enough to make it stop. You threw stones until your arm grew sore, then you threw with your other hand until that one ached as well. Daily, you climbed as close to the sun as you could, until the surrounding peaks were barren of anything you could lift. Every day, you would return home, your skin blistered and burning red, and you would curse the sun.

You remember how you later tried to hide. How you would seal yourself indoors for half the year, living in perfect, blissful, safe darkness. You remember putting up blackout curtains, and the wall full of clocks — all meticulously timed against the farmer's almanac — tracking a precise sunset and sunrise for every day of the year. It wasn't enough. You could leave the house and still feel the remnants of the day's heat. You could see how the flowers sealed at night, humbling themselves against the contrast of the night's incomparable beauty. And yet these very same plants would hide themselves in the soil until the year's span when the sun's hunger had swallowed more than its share of the sky.

You remember your family, your friends, sitting you down, at four in the morning, to talk.

"This has gone on for too long," they had said. "It's gone too far."

"You need help," they said. "Let us help you."

And so, you remember how you stayed awake with them, blackout curtains left open. You remember when the sunlight finally bled through the windows, profaning all that it touched as it crept its way across your floor. You held back your movements but couldn't repress the revulsion that rippled through you like so many waves in a tide as it anchored itself to your feet and climbed its way up your legs.

You had spat on the carpet then, and the look you saw shared by the people gathered was no less clear to you then as it remains now.

But the line had been crossed; the holdback was broken. You knew your enemy. You understood it — this golden sphere above. You went out in the day again. You would wake while the sky had not yet cleansed itself of its brazen stain.

You remember your family, your friends, breathing a collective sigh of relief as you slipped from their minds. How they believed their problem solved and stopped noticing you, as they no longer noticed the sun. How some things, they had said, were fixed — how they would never change.

You remember your first feature and how the crowds gathered in their hundreds to study your works. Paintings of the sun; in all its forms of being. Paintings of the sunspots, of the solar flares and eclipses, and of the sun hanging in the sky, as seen from a hilltop.

You were commended for your keen eye, for your attention to detail. For capturing so truthfully the essence of the beast. For the brutal radiance of your pieces; shown alone by necessity, so as to not overwhelm viewers with their monstrosity.

You remember how days later, the fire burned through the paintings with all the fury that it could have mustered. You had piled them all on the forecourt of the gallery, and focused the sun's very own spite through a lens to set itself alight.

"Such violence cannot be tolerated!" You had screamed into the crowd, but your words were lost amidst the roaring of flame and flashes of photography.